ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Higher Education and Research English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.

- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.

- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.

- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.

- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

acknowledgment
Recognition of another person's contribution or confirmation that a message was received.

analysis assumption
A condition treated as true for the purpose of an analysis.

authorship
Recognized responsibility and credit for creating a scholarly or other written work.

conference Q&A
The question-and-answer discussion associated with a conference presentation.

contribution
A person's or activity's part in producing a shared result.

control
A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

corresponding author
The author designated to coordinate communication about a scholarly publication.

feasibility
Whether a proposed activity can reasonably be carried out under stated conditions.

future work
Further questions or activities proposed after the current study or project.

generalizability
The extent to which findings may apply beyond the people or conditions studied.

human subjects
People whose participation or identifiable information is involved in research under the applicable definition.

hypothesis
A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence.

informed consent
A process of providing relevant information and obtaining voluntary agreement under applicable requirements.

innovation
A new or improved approach, product, or process intended to create value.

IRB
Institutional review board: a body that reviews covered human-subjects research under applicable requirements.

limitation
A condition that restricts what evidence, work, or a conclusion can establish.

major revision
A publication decision requiring substantial changes before a manuscript is reconsidered.

metadata
Information describing data, such as its source, units, dates, and structure.

methodology
The methods and reasoning used to conduct a study or analysis.

peer review
Evaluation of scholarly work by others with relevant expertise.

protocol drift
A gradual or unnoticed departure from the planned study or working procedure.

provenance
The documented origin and history of data or an item.

replication
Repeating a study or test to examine whether a finding holds again.

repository
A managed location for storing and accessing data, documents, or code.

reproducibility
Obtaining consistent results using the same data and methods; conventions vary by research field.

research question
The specific question a study is designed to investigate.

response letter
A document replying to comments or questions and explaining the changes or reasoning.

scope

Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

secondary use

Use of data or material for a purpose beyond the original collection or primary purpose.

significance

The importance of a question or finding; statistical significance has a separate technical meaning.

specific aims

The focused objectives a research proposal intends to achieve.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is ... .

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for ... . The correct information is ... .

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses ... .

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Research Questions and Study Design

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

03 | Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Research Ethics and Human Subjects

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements? Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

05 | Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

06 | Peer Review and Revision Responses

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

07 | Data Management and Reproducibility

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

08 | Academic Presentations and Conferences

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

US Department of Education: FERPA

https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.